Journal for My Daughter

By Stanley J. Kunitz

INTRODUCTION

We all know the stereotype. He's the clued-out dad who doesn't know an iPod from IHOP; the guy with the wallet whose relationship with his kids, especially if they're daughters, is decidedly background.

As the primary male role model in a girl's life, however, fathers influence their daughters in profound ways, from how they see themselves to what they come to expect from men and the world at large.

Men often don't realize the importance of their interactions or may shy away from too close involvement because of their inexperience, or conditioning. Some may even resort to a relationship via the written word rather than face-to-face interaction. Such is the case in Stanley J. Kunitz' Journal for My Daughter.

1

Your turn. Grass of confusion.

You say you had a father once:

his name was absence.

He left, but did not let you go.

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Part of him, more than a shadow,

beckoned down corridors,

secret, elusive, saturnine,

melting at your touch.

In the crack

of a divided house

grew the resentment-weed.

It has white inconspicuous flowers

Family of anthologists!

Collectors of injuries!

2

I wake to a glittering world,

to the annunciation of the frost.

A popeyed chipmunk scurries past.

the pockets of his cheeks bulging.

As the field mice store seeds,

as the needle-nosed shrew

threading under the woodpile

deposits little heaps of land-snails

for milestones on its runways,

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I propose
that we gather our affections
Lambkin, I care.

3

I was happy you were born,
your banks of digits
equipped for decimals,
and all your clever parts
neatly in place.
Your nation gives me joy,
as it has always given.
If I could have my choice
on the way to exile
I think I'd rather sleep forever
Than wake up cold
In a country without women.

4

You cried. You cried.
You wasted and you cried.

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Night after night
I walked the floor with you,
croaking the same old
tranquilizing song,
the only tune
I ever learned to carry.
In the rosy tissue
of your brain
where memory begins,
that theme is surely scored,
waiting till you need
to play it back.
There were three crows
Sat on a tree
Sing Billy Magee Magaw.
You do not need to sing to me.
I like the sound of your voice
even when you phone from school
Asking for money.

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5

There was a big blond uncle-bear,
wounded, smoke-eyed, wild,
who shambled from the west
with his big bags full of havoc.
He spoke the bear's grunt-language,
waving his paws
and rocking on his legs.
both of us were drunk,
slapping each other on the back,
sweaty with genius.
He spouted his nonsense-rhymes,
roaring like a behemoth.
You crawled under the sofa.

6

Goodies are shaken
From the papa-tree:
Be what you are. Give
what is yours to give.
Have style. Dare.

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Such a storm of fortune cookies!
Outside your room
stands the white-headed prowler
in his multiple disguises
who reminds you of your likeness.
Wherever you turn,
down the street,
in the fugues of appetite,
in the groin of nightmare,
he waits for you,
haggard with his thousand years.
His agents are everywhere,
His heart is at home
in your own generation;
the folded message in his hands
is stiff with dirt and wine-stains,
older than the Dead Sea Scrolls.
Daughter, read:
What do I want of my life?
More! More!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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